The Coronavirus Crisis, Welfarism and the BJP's Political Response

The RBI voter perception numbers did show a decline in 2020-21. (Figures 10.3 and 10.4). The disruption of the COVID-19 lockdown and the huge migrant crisis that followed led to speculation that Modi's political leeway may not endure. By September 2020, 10.4 million (1.04 crore) Indian migrants had moved across states. The Union government claimed that under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana (Poor Welfare Scheme), launched on 20 June 2020, it had distributed financial assistance worth ₹688 billion (68,820 crore) to 420 million (42 crore) Indians by 15 September 2020. While it did not keep a central count of migrant deaths, the government told Parliament it had distributed free rations to 800 million Indians (80 crore) during the lockdown months under a scheme that continued until 20 November 2020.[29]

To narrow-focus on a key BJP-ruled state, UP saw the return of 3.8 million migrants due to the national lockdown.[30] Some leading economists had criticised Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's post-lockdown 'administrative' approach of issuing a 'Request for Proposal' for a 'consultant' to create a 'One Trillion Dollar Economy for Uttar Pradesh' by 2025,[31] but the state government's district-wise mapping of coronavirus migrants is revealing. UP registered 3.4 million migrants district-wise, and they were skill-mapped across ninety-four job categories. The range this survey covered is hugely diverse: from ayahs, carpenters, blacksmiths and escalator-fixers to nutritionists, gym-trainers and beauticians. By September 2020, 2.4 million of these migrants had been employed for tasks under MNREGS. Furthermore, as many as 5.3 million people in the state had received direct cash transfers of ₹1,000 in financial assistance from the state during the lockdown; 2.9 million of them got a second instalment as well.[32]

The numbers on welfare-spending through DBTs indicate how the BJP managed to partly mitigate the political impact of the economic miseries caused by the lockdown in 2020. The Modi government's critics, such as the Congress's former finance minister